

ON TECHNIQUE

Micropolyphony

After World War II, a number of composers, especially in Central and Eastern Europe, adopted a technique using massive clusters of notes to form “blocks” of sound, in which texture takes precedence over the traditional parameters of harmony and melody. Not satisfied with the necessarily static nature of these cluster chords, Ligeti developed the technique a stage further, superimposing a large number of independent melodies (what he called “micropolyphony”), so that the individual parts are indiscernible, and the block is perceived as a dynamic, constantly changing whole.



LIKE LIGETI'S MICROPOLYPHONY, THESE
STARLINGS APPEAR AS A SINGLE ENTITY

That he was born in Transylvania, with all its Gothic horror associations, later appealed to György Ligeti's dark sense of humor. He came from a Hungarian Jewish family, and was born